

01

NATURE OF RELIGIOUS LANGUAGE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

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MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

□ Fact: An ICML 2026 paper on Sanskrit–English translation reports that purely statistical generation can cause semantic drift in culturally embedded and ritual concepts, and proposes dictionary, morpho-syntactic and glossary-grounded decoding to preserve sacred entities and terminology. □□ Inference: This contemporary translation problem illustrates a core philosophical point: religious meaning is not exhausted by word substitution.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

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ANSWER LINE: □ Fact: An ICML 2026 paper on Sanskrit–English translation reports that purely statistical generation can cause semantic drift in culturally embedded and ritual concepts, and proposes dictionary, morpho-syntactic and glossary-grounded decoding to preserve sacred entities and terminology. □□ Inference: This contemporary translation problem illustrates a core philosophical point: religious meaning is not exhausted by word substitution.

02

NATURE OF RELIGIOUS LANGUAGE: CORE DISTINCTIONS

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

[Symbolic] "Is religious language symbolic? / Tillich on symbol." (2025, 2023) → §2(b). [Analogical] "Analogical nature of religious language (Aquinas)." (2024) → §2(a). [Cog/non-cog] "Distinguish cognitivist & non-cognitivist accounts (Braithwaite / 'God exists')." (2024, 2022) → §3. [Wittgenstein] "Wittgenstein on the non-cognitive nature of religious language." (2023) → §3. [Advaita] "Anirvacanīyatā & the nature of religious language." (2025) → §2(d) + §9.5. [Secular vs religious] "In what sense is the secular use of language different from the religious use?" (2018, 10m) → §9.6 — function, not vocabulary. [Symbol→mysticism] "Does religious symbolism lead to mysticism?" (2019, 20m) → §9.7 — answer whether and how, and include the negative case. [Transcendent referent] "Religious symbols as transcendent referent mediating into the cultural, spatial and temporal world." (2018, 15m) → §9.2 + §9.7 (Eliade's hierophany; Tillich's participation). [Cognitive content] "Does religious language carry cognitive content?" (2020, 20m) → §9.9 — the spectrum, plus the falsification debate. [Braithwaite] "Non-cognitive theory of religious language, in the light of Braithwaite." (2021, 20m) → §9.4 + §9.9 position 7. [Analogy] "The analogical nature of religious language." (2024, 10m) → §9.1 + §9.8 — add Scotus for the contrast. [Pluralism bridge] "How does a theory of religious language bear on religious pluralism?" → §9.10.

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

So "good" applies proportionally, truly but not identically. → preserves meaning without anthropomorphism. (b) Symbol (Tillich — 2023, 2025 PYQ): □ Religious language is symbolic, not literal.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

□ The strong answer: religious language is neither literal nor meaningless — analogy/symbol give it cognitive meaning (realist), while non-cognitivists (Braithwaite/Wittgenstein) capture its practical/moral force but at the cost of its truth-claim; the believer's own intent is cognitivist.

ANSWER LINE: Religious language is discourse about transcendent reality whose central problem is how finite human concepts can be meaningful without reducing their object to finite categories.